

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Botanist Hana Virtanen has claimed that the bright ultraviolet patterns on certain orchid petals evolved specifically to attract bee pollinators rather than to deter herbivores.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Virtanen's claim?

A: Herbivorous insects that feed on orchid leaves are unable to perceive ultraviolet light at any wavelength.

B: Orchid species with the brightest ultraviolet patterns grow in habitats where herbivore populations are unusually low.

C: Bees visited orchid flowers with intact ultraviolet patterns roughly four times as often as they visited otherwise identical flowers whose ultraviolet patterns had been chemically masked.

D: Ultraviolet petal patterns are also found in several plant families that are pollinated primarily by wind.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Virtanen's claim is about ATTRACTING BEES. C manipulates the pattern and measures bee visits directly. A only rules out the alternative (herbivores) without showing bees are attracted. B is correlational and about habitat. D undercuts the claim by showing the pattern in wind-pollinated plants. TRICK: Ruling out the alternative is not the same as proving the claim -- look for direct evidence of the proposed mechanism.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Sleep researcher Idris Bello has argued that reading a printed book before bedtime helps people fall asleep faster than reading on a backlit tablet does.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Bello's argument?

A: Participants who read a printed book for 30 minutes before bed fell asleep an average of 12 minutes sooner than participants who read on a backlit tablet for the same duration.

B: Participants who read printed books reported enjoying the experience more than participants who read on tablets.

C: Participants who used tablets with the backlight dimmed fell asleep sooner than participants who used tablets at full brightness.

D: Adults who own physical books report going to bed earlier on average than adults who own only e-readers.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The claim compares PRINT vs. BACKLIT TABLET on TIME TO FALL ASLEEP. A tests exactly that. B measures enjoyment. C compares two tablet settings, not print vs. tablet. D measures bedtime, not sleep onset, and is correlational. TRICK: Check that both the comparison AND the outcome match the claim.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Music educator Rosalind Achebe has claimed that learning to read musical notation improves students' ability to recognize patterns in mathematics.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Achebe's claim?

A: Students enrolled in school music programs had higher average mathematics grades than students not enrolled in music programs.

B: Professional musicians scored higher than non-musicians on a test of pattern recognition.

C: Students who reported enjoying mathematics were more likely to sign up for elective music courses.

D: Students randomly assigned to a six-week notation-reading course scored higher on a subsequent mathematical pattern-recognition test than students randomly assigned to a music-appreciation course with no notation instruction.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: D is the only option with RANDOM ASSIGNMENT, which rules out self-selection.

A, B, and C are all correlational: students who choose music may already be stronger.

TRICK: When a claim says X improves Y, look for random assignment. Self-selected groups cannot establish that the training caused the improvement.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Veterinarian Soo-Min Park has argued that providing shelter dogs with daily puzzle feeders reduces stress-related behaviors such as repetitive pacing.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Park's argument?

A: Shelter dogs that received puzzle feeders took longer to finish their meals than dogs fed from standard bowls.

B: Shelter dogs given daily puzzle feeders spent 40 percent less time pacing than a matched group of dogs fed from standard bowls over the same four-week period.

C: Dogs in shelters with outdoor play areas paced less than dogs in shelters without them.

D: Shelter staff reported that dogs appeared more engaged during feeding times after puzzle feeders were introduced.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: The claim is puzzle feeders REDUCE PACING. B compares feeder dogs to a matched control on the exact behavior. A measures feeding duration, not stress. C tests a different intervention (play areas). D reports engagement during feeding, not overall pacing. TRICK: The outcome measured must be the exact behavior named in the claim, and there must be a comparison group.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Historian Bernadette Cho has claimed that the widespread adoption of mechanical clocks in fourteenth-century European towns changed how laborers understood the workday, shifting it from a task-based to a time-based structure.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Cho's claim?

A: Mechanical clocks became common features of town squares across Europe during the fourteenth century.

B: Fourteenth-century European laborers worked longer hours on average than laborers in the previous century.

C: Employment contracts from towns that installed public clocks increasingly specified fixed daily hours, whereas contracts from towns without clocks continued to define obligations by tasks completed.

D: Mechanical clocks of the fourteenth century were often inaccurate, losing or gaining as much as fifteen minutes per day.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Cho claims clocks changed the CONCEPTION of the workday from task-based to time-based. C compares contract language in clock towns vs. non-clock towns -- direct evidence of the shift. A restates the premise (clocks spread) without showing the effect. B measures hours worked, not how work was defined. D is irrelevant to the conceptual shift. TRICK: A premise restated is not evidence. Look for the OUTCOME the claim predicts.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Nutrition researcher Emeka Dubois has hypothesized that eating breakfast improves children's performance on morning reading assessments.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Dubois's hypothesis?

A: In a controlled study, children who ate breakfast and children who skipped breakfast scored nearly identically on a reading assessment administered at 10 a.m.

B: Children who ate breakfast reported feeling more alert during morning classes than children who skipped breakfast.

C: Children who ate a high-protein breakfast outperformed children who ate a high-sugar breakfast on morning reading assessments.

D: Schools that introduced free breakfast programs saw a modest rise in average reading scores over three years.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: To WEAKEN, find evidence that breakfast does NOT improve reading. A shows no difference in scores. B, C, and D all support the hypothesis in some form. TRICK: For weaken questions, three options will typically support the claim. Find the one showing no effect or the opposite effect.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Civil engineer Naledi Mokoena has claimed that installing roundabouts at intersections reduces the number of injury-causing collisions compared to traffic signals.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Mokoena's claim?

A: Drivers reported feeling less frustrated at roundabouts than at signalized intersections.

B: Roundabouts allowed vehicles to pass through intersections at a higher average rate than traffic signals did.

C: Intersections converted to roundabouts saw a decrease in the total number of collisions of all types, including minor fender benders in parking areas nearby.

D: Intersections converted from traffic signals to roundabouts experienced 38 percent fewer injury-causing collisions in the three years after conversion than in the three years before.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: The claim specifies INJURY-CAUSING collisions. D measures exactly that with a before-after comparison. A measures frustration. B measures throughput. C measures ALL collisions including unrelated parking incidents -- a broader and vaguer measure. TRICK: When a claim narrows the outcome (injury-causing, not all collisions), the evidence must match that narrower category.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Archaeologist Tomasz Wieczorek has proposed that a group of Bronze Age settlements in the Carpathian foothills were abandoned because of a prolonged regional drought rather than because of armed conflict.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Wieczorek's proposal?

A: Excavations at the settlements uncovered no weapons of any kind in the residential areas.

B: Tree-ring and sediment records indicate a severe multi-decade drought beginning shortly before the settlements were abandoned, and the abandoned structures show no signs of burning, weapon damage, or hasty departure.

C: Neighboring settlements in wetter valleys to the north remained occupied for several centuries after the Carpathian sites were abandoned.

D: Pottery styles at the settlements changed markedly in the decades before abandonment, suggesting contact with outside groups.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Wieczorek's claim has two parts: drought caused it AND conflict did not. B provides both -- drought evidence with correct timing, plus absence of conflict markers. A only rules out conflict weakly (no weapons found does not prove no attack). C is consistent with drought but does not link it to these sites. D suggests outside contact, which could point toward conflict. TRICK: For 'X rather than Y' claims, the best evidence establishes X and rules out Y.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Toxicologist Priyanka Raval has argued that airborne particulate pollution from a nearby highway is the primary cause of elevated asthma rates in an adjacent residential district.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Raval's argument?

A: Residents of the district report higher rates of asthma than the national average.

B: The district contains several older buildings with documented mold problems, which are also known to trigger asthma.

C: Asthma rates within the district decline steadily with distance from the highway, falling by roughly half at each additional 200 meters, and this gradient persists after adjusting for household income and building age.

D: Particulate concentrations measured beside the highway exceed national air quality standards during peak traffic hours.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: C shows a DOSE-RESPONSE GRADIENT: more exposure produces more disease, and confounders are controlled. A establishes the problem but no cause. B introduces a competing cause, weakening the argument. D shows the pollutant is present but not that it causes the asthma. TRICK: A dose-response relationship -- effect scaling with exposure -- is among the strongest forms of causal evidence.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Sports scientist Joakim Lindqvist has claimed that wearing compression garments during recovery reduces muscle soreness after intense exercise. Critics have countered that any observed benefit is a placebo effect driven by athletes' expectations.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Lindqvist's claim against this specific criticism?

A: In a trial where athletes wore either true compression garments or visually identical sham garments that applied negligible pressure, and no athlete knew which type they had received, the true-compression group reported significantly less soreness.

B: Athletes who wore compression garments reported significantly less soreness than athletes who wore no garments at all.

C: Blood tests showed lower levels of a muscle-damage marker in athletes who wore compression garments.

D: A majority of professional athletes surveyed said they believe compression garments aid recovery.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The criticism is specifically about PLACEBO. Only A uses blinding with a sham control, which isolates the physical effect from expectation. B has no blinding

-- athletes know they are wearing garments, so placebo remains possible. C shows a mechanism but athletes were still unblinded. D measures belief, which is the placebo mechanism itself. TRICK: When the objection is placebo, the answer must involve blinding and a sham control.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Security analyst Farida Haddad has claimed that a newly deployed screening algorithm is highly effective at identifying fraudulent insurance claims.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Haddad's claim?

A: The algorithm flagged 8 percent of all submitted claims for further review.

B: Investigators required an average of six hours to review each flagged claim.

C: The algorithm was trained on claims data from a single regional office.

D: Of the claims the algorithm flagged as fraudulent, subsequent investigation confirmed fraud in only 4 percent, while the algorithm failed to flag more than half of the claims later independently confirmed as fraudulent.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: D attacks BOTH precision (96% of flags were false alarms) and recall (over half of real fraud was missed) -- the two measures that define effectiveness. A gives a flag rate with no accuracy information. B concerns cost, not accuracy. C raises a generalizability concern but does not show the algorithm performs poorly. TRICK: 'Effective at identifying' requires both catching real cases and avoiding false alarms. Attack either or both.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Developmental psychologist Camille Ferreira has argued that frequent parent-child conversation causes children to develop larger vocabularies.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Ferreira's argument?

A: Children with larger vocabularies tend to have parents with more years of formal education.

B: A longitudinal study found that children's early vocabulary size predicted how much parents later spoke with them, but parents' earlier speech volume did not predict children's later vocabulary growth.

C: Some children with limited parent-child conversation nonetheless developed average vocabularies.

D: Parent-child conversation frequency varies widely across households, even within the same neighborhood.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: B reverses the arrow: children's vocabulary drives parental speech, not the other way around. That directly undermines the causal direction Ferreira claims. A suggests a confound (education) but does not establish reverse causation. C shows exceptions but not a mechanism. D describes variation without addressing causation. TRICK: Reverse causation is when the proposed effect is actually the cause. Longitudinal ordering is the test.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Business researcher Oleg Petrov has claimed that companies that adopt flexible remote-work policies achieve higher employee retention than companies that require full-time office attendance.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Petrov's claim?

- A: The companies in Petrov's sample adopted remote-work policies only after already achieving unusually high retention, and firms that adopted such policies while struggling with turnover were excluded because many closed before the study period ended.
- B: Some employees at remote-friendly companies report feeling isolated from colleagues.
- C: Companies with remote-work policies tend to be concentrated in the technology sector.
- D: Retention rates at remote-friendly companies declined slightly during a recent economic downturn.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: A identifies SELECTION BIAS: the sample was built from companies that were already doing well, and failures were excluded. That means the correlation may reflect which companies survived, not what the policy caused. B notes a drawback but not a flaw in the evidence. C raises a generalizability point. D shows a decline but does not compare to office-based firms. TRICK: When the sample excludes failures, high performance in the survivors proves nothing about the policy.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Education analyst Wanjiru Kamau has claimed that a district's new tutoring program improved mathematics achievement for students at every skill level.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Kamau's claim?

A: The district's overall average mathematics score rose by only two points after the program was introduced.

B: The tutoring program was more expensive per student than the district had originally projected.

C: Although the district's overall average rose, scores for students who began in the lowest quartile declined slightly, with the overall gain driven entirely by students who began in the top two quartiles.

D: Some students assigned to tutoring attended fewer than half of the scheduled sessions.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Kamau claims improvement at EVERY skill level. C shows one subgroup got worse, directly contradicting 'every level' even though the aggregate improved. A questions the size of the gain but not its distribution. B concerns cost. D concerns implementation, not outcomes. TRICK: Universal claims ('every,' 'all,' 'across the board') are broken by a single subgroup exception -- check whether aggregate gains mask subgroup losses.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Ecologist Bartholomew Nkemdirim has proposed that the return of a keystone predator to a river valley is sufficient on its own to restore the valley's native songbird populations.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Nkemdirim's proposal?

A: Songbird populations in the valley have increased since the predator's return.

B: The predator preys mainly on deer, which browse the shrubs songbirds nest in.

C: Songbird populations in a neighboring valley without the predator have remained stable.

D: In three valleys where the predator returned but invasive shrub species had already replaced native vegetation, songbird populations showed no recovery over the following decade.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: 'Sufficient on its own' means the predator alone guarantees recovery. D shows cases where the predator returned yet recovery did NOT occur, proving other conditions are also required. A supports the proposal. B explains a mechanism, which supports it. C is a neutral comparison. TRICK: To break a sufficiency claim, find a case where the cause is present but the effect is absent.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Urban researcher Cliodhna Byrne has argued that a city's new bike-lane network has increased the number of residents who commute by bicycle.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Byrne's argument?

A: Some residents continue to commute by car despite the new bike lanes.

B: The city measured bicycle use with sensors placed only on the new bike lanes, and surveys indicate that most riders counted had previously cycled to work on adjacent streets rather than being new cyclists.

C: Construction of the bike-lane network took longer than the city had planned.

D: Bicycle commuting rates are higher in cities with milder winters than in this city.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: B shows the MEASUREMENT captures rerouting, not new cyclists -- so the apparent increase may be an artifact of where sensors were placed. A notes that some drivers remain, which does not contradict an increase. C concerns construction timelines. D is an irrelevant cross-city comparison. TRICK: Check whether the instrument measures what the claim asserts. Counting riders on new lanes does not distinguish new cyclists from relocated ones.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Fisheries manager Halvard Osen has claimed that a catch limit introduced in 2019 successfully reversed the decline of a coastal cod population.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Osen's claim?

A: The cod population rose sharply in 2020 and 2021 but has fallen every year since, and the 2025 population is lower than the 2018 level that prompted the limit.

B: Some fishing vessels exceeded the catch limit in its first year of enforcement.

C: Cod populations in a neighboring region without catch limits also rose in 2020.

D: The catch limit reduced total landings by 30 percent relative to the previous five-year average.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: A shows the apparent recovery was temporary and the population is now worse than before -- the reversal did not hold. C is a strong distractor because it suggests an outside cause, but it covers only one year and one region. B concerns compliance. D confirms the limit changed fishing behavior but says nothing about the population. TRICK: When a claim cites a recovery, check whether the full time series supports it or whether a short window was selected.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Anthropologist Ingrid Solberg has argued that a distinctive style of stone tool found across three separate island groups spread through direct trade contact between the islands.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Solberg's argument?

A: The tools on all three island groups were made from locally available stone.

B: Similar tools have been found on a fourth island group not previously known to archaeologists.

C: Radiocarbon dating shows the tool style appeared on all three island groups within the same fifty-year window, a period during which prevailing currents and seasonal winds made inter-island voyaging virtually impossible.

D: The tools show minor stylistic variations from one island group to another.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: C undermines the trade mechanism by showing contact was physically impossible during the relevant period, pointing toward independent invention or an earlier common origin. A is a strong distractor -- local stone is consistent with the IDEA spreading through trade even if materials did not. B extends the pattern without addressing the mechanism. D is expected under any transmission model. TRICK: To weaken a mechanism claim, show the mechanism could not have operated, not merely that details vary.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Pharmacologist Adaeze Umeh has claimed that a new formulation of a common pain reliever provides meaningfully faster relief than the standard formulation.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Umeh's claim?

A: The new formulation costs more to manufacture than the standard formulation.

B: A small number of participants reported mild nausea after taking the new formulation.

C: The new formulation dissolves more quickly in laboratory conditions than the standard formulation.

D: Across a large trial, the new formulation produced relief an average of 90 seconds sooner than the standard formulation, a difference that patients in a blinded follow-up were unable to distinguish.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: D concedes a measurable difference but shows it is not MEANINGFUL -- patients cannot perceive it. Umeh's word 'meaningfully' is the target. A concerns cost. B concerns side effects. C actually supports faster action. TRICK: A statistically detectable difference is not automatically a meaningful one. When a claim says 'meaningfully,' attack practical significance, not existence.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Agricultural scientist Mateo Salazar has argued that a new drought-tolerant wheat variety will maintain yields for farmers throughout the semi-arid plains region.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Salazar's argument?

A: The new variety requires slightly more nitrogen fertilizer than conventional wheat.

B: The variety was tested exclusively on research plots with deep loam soils and supplemental irrigation available during establishment, conditions that fewer than one in ten farms in the semi-arid plains can provide.

C: Some farmers in the region have expressed reluctance to switch from familiar wheat varieties.

D: The variety produces grain with a slightly different protein content than conventional wheat.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: B shows the testing conditions do not resemble the conditions where the variety is supposed to work -- an EXTERNAL VALIDITY problem. The results may not transfer to real farms. A and D note trade-offs, not failures of the yield claim. C concerns adoption willingness, not performance. TRICK: When a claim projects results onto a broad population, check whether the study conditions match that population's actual conditions.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: School administrator Lucian Marchetti has claimed that an intensive intervention program raises test scores, citing the fact that students selected for the program because of unusually poor scores on one exam improved substantially on the next.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Marchetti's claim?

A: Some students in the program attended fewer sessions than the program required.

B: Students in the program reported finding the sessions helpful and engaging.

C: A comparison group of students with equally poor initial scores who received no intervention improved by approximately the same amount on the next exam.

D: The program's instructors were more experienced than the district's average teacher.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: C exposes REGRESSION TO THE MEAN: students selected for extreme low scores tend to score closer to their true average next time regardless of intervention. An untreated group improving equally shows the program added nothing. A and D concern implementation quality. B measures satisfaction. TRICK: When a group is selected for an extreme score, expect movement toward the average on its own. Only a control group starting equally extreme can separate the effect from the artifact.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Physician-researcher Yusra Alkhatib has claimed that a particular surgical procedure produces worse long-term outcomes than nonsurgical management, citing registry data showing higher complication rates among surgical patients.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Alkhatib's claim?

A: Surgeons in the registry recommended the procedure primarily to patients whose disease was already advanced, while patients with milder disease were managed nonsurgically, and no adjustment was made for baseline severity.

B: The registry included patients from more than two hundred hospitals across several countries.

C: Some surgeons in the registry performed the procedure more frequently than others.

D: Nonsurgical management typically requires ongoing medication with its own side effects.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: A identifies CONFOUNDING BY INDICATION: the sicker patients got surgery, so worse outcomes may reflect their initial condition rather than the operation. Without severity adjustment, the comparison is invalid. B is a strength of the data, not a weakness. C notes variation without linking it to outcomes. D notes a drawback of the alternative but does not address the comparison's validity. TRICK: When treatment assignment depends on how sick patients already are, raw outcome comparisons are misleading.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Cognitive scientist Ravi Balakrishnan has argued that bilingualism delays the onset of dementia symptoms by building cognitive reserve, and that this protective effect operates independently of educational attainment.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Balakrishnan's argument?

- A: Bilingual individuals in the study were diagnosed with dementia symptoms an average of four years later than monolingual individuals.
- B: Brain imaging showed comparable levels of underlying pathology in bilingual and monolingual patients at the time of diagnosis.
- C: Some bilingual individuals in the sample had learned their second language in adulthood rather than childhood.
- D: After statistically adjusting for years of formal education, the difference in age at symptom onset between bilingual and monolingual individuals shrank to less than six months and was no longer statistically distinguishable from zero.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Balakrishnan's claim has TWO parts: bilingualism delays onset AND does so independently of education. D attacks the second part directly -- once education is controlled, the effect nearly vanishes, meaning education explains it. A supports the first part. B supports the cognitive-reserve mechanism. C introduces variation but no contradiction. TRICK: When a claim asserts an effect is independent of a confounder, the killer evidence is the effect disappearing after adjusting for that confounder.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Methodologist Sinead O'Farrell has claimed that a particular behavioral technique reliably improves workplace productivity, citing a review of twenty-two published studies that nearly all reported positive effects.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken O'Farrell's claim?

A: The twenty-two studies used slightly different measures of productivity.

B: A registry of preregistered trials of the same technique contains thirty-one completed studies, of which only nine were ever published, and the twenty-two unpublished studies reported null or negative effects.

C: The published studies were conducted across a range of industries and company sizes.

D: The technique requires a brief training session for supervisors before implementation.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: B reveals PUBLICATION BIAS: the published literature is a filtered sample, and the full evidence base is mostly null. The apparent consistency is an artifact of what got published. A notes measurement heterogeneity but does not overturn the direction of findings. C is a strength (broad applicability). D concerns implementation. TRICK: When a claim rests on published studies all agreeing, ask what happened to the studies that were never published.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Historian Perpetua Nwankwo has argued that a sixteenth-century chronicle provides independent confirmation of events described in an earlier royal annal, strengthening the case that those events occurred as described.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Nwankwo's argument?

A: Textual analysis shows that the sixteenth-century chronicle reproduces the annal's account nearly verbatim in the relevant passages, including a distinctive scribal error present in the annal's only surviving manuscript.

B: The sixteenth-century chronicle contains several passages describing events for which no other source survives.

C: The royal annal was composed within a generation of the events it describes.

D: The sixteenth-century chronicler is known to have traveled widely before compiling the work.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: A destroys INDEPENDENCE: the chronicle is copying the annal, including a unique error, so it is not a second witness but a derivative of the first. Two sources that trace to one origin provide no additional confirmation. B and D would tend to support the chronicle's independent value. C strengthens the annal's reliability but says nothing about independence. TRICK: 'Independent confirmation' requires sources that do not derive from one another. A shared distinctive error proves derivation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 26

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Software researcher Dmitri Sokolov has claimed that a redesigned interface produces no improvement in task completion speed, citing a trial in which experienced users completed tasks at the same rate under both the old and new designs.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Sokolov's claim?

A: Experienced users reported preferring the new interface's visual style.

B: The trial included users from several different departments within the company.

C: The tasks in the trial were simple enough that experienced users reached the maximum achievable speed under both designs, whereas in a separate trial using complex tasks, the new design reduced completion time by 22 percent.

D: The new interface required a larger software download than the old interface.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: C identifies a CEILING EFFECT: the tasks were too easy to detect any difference because performance was already maxed out. When harder tasks are used, the improvement appears. A measures preference, not speed. B concerns sampling. D is irrelevant to speed. TRICK: A null result can mean the measure could not detect a difference. Check whether the task was too easy (ceiling) or too hard (floor) to show variation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 27

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Energy analyst Ottoline Reyes-Vargas has claimed that a national program of household solar subsidies reduced the country's total electricity-sector carbon emissions.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Reyes-Vargas's claim?

A: Household solar installations increased fivefold during the subsidy period.

B: The subsidies cost more per installation than the government had projected.

C: Some households that installed solar panels continued to draw electricity from the grid at night.

D: Grid operators responded to reduced daytime demand by idling low-emission natural gas plants first while keeping higher-emission coal plants running continuously, so total sector emissions were essentially unchanged despite the growth in solar capacity.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: D shows the causal chain broke at the system level: solar grew, but grid dispatch decisions meant emissions did not fall. The claim is about EMISSIONS, not capacity. A confirms solar growth without confirming emissions fell -- an intermediate step, not the outcome. B concerns cost. C describes normal solar behavior. TRICK: When a claim spans a causal chain (subsidy leads to solar leads to lower emissions), the weakness may lie in a later link, not the first.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 28

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Linguist Anneliese Vogt has argued that a distinctive vowel shift in a regional dialect originated among younger urban speakers and then spread outward to rural areas, rather than the reverse.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Vogt's argument?

A: Rural speakers over sixty use the shifted vowel less frequently than urban speakers over sixty.

B: Recordings made across four decades show the shifted vowel appearing first among urban speakers born in the 1970s, then among rural speakers born in the 1980s, and finally among rural speakers in the most remote districts born in the 1990s.

C: Urban speakers of all ages currently use the shifted vowel more frequently than rural speakers of all ages.

D: The shifted vowel is more common in informal speech than in formal speech across both urban and rural populations.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Vogt's claim is about DIRECTION OF SPREAD OVER TIME. B provides a chronological sequence showing urban first, then progressively more remote rural areas -- exactly the diffusion pattern claimed. C shows a current snapshot consistent with either direction of spread. A compares one age band only. D concerns register, not geography.

TRICK: Claims about spread require time-ordered data. A present-day difference cannot establish which direction the feature traveled.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 29

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Epidemiologist Kwabena Mensah has argued that a workplace wellness program reduces employee sick days, and that this reduction reflects genuine health improvement rather than employees simply being reluctant to report absences.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Mensah's argument?

A: Participants in the program showed measurable improvements in blood pressure and resting heart rate relative to non-participants, and their reduction in sick days was matched by a comparable decline in insurance claims for acute illness, which employees have no incentive to underreport.

B: Participants took an average of three fewer sick days per year than non-participants.

C: Participants reported feeling healthier at the end of the program than at the beginning.

D: Enrollment in the wellness program grew each year it was offered.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Mensah must rule out UNDERREPORTING. A provides objective physiological measures plus insurance claims, which employees cannot suppress -- so the decline is real, not reporting behavior. B shows the effect but is exactly the measure vulnerable to the underreporting objection. C is self-reported and equally vulnerable. D measures popularity. TRICK: When the objection is that a measure is unreliable, the answer must supply a measure not subject to that same distortion.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 30

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Transportation researcher Beatriz Almeida has claimed that a new vehicle safety feature has made driving more dangerous for pedestrians, noting that the number of pedestrian collisions involving vehicles equipped with the feature has risen sharply over the past five years.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Almeida's claim?

A: Pedestrian collisions involving vehicles without the feature also rose over the same period.

B: The safety feature was designed primarily to protect vehicle occupants rather than pedestrians.

C: The number of vehicles equipped with the feature grew from roughly 40,000 to more than 3 million over the five-year period, and the rate of pedestrian collisions per equipped vehicle fell by nearly two-thirds.

D: Some drivers of equipped vehicles report relying on the feature more than the manufacturer recommends.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: C shows the rising raw COUNT is explained by explosive growth in the number of equipped vehicles, while the RATE per vehicle fell sharply -- the feature is associated with fewer collisions, not more. A is a strong distractor but only shows a general trend without addressing the rate. B concerns design intent. D suggests risk compensation, which would support Almeida. TRICK: A rising total can hide a falling rate. When the population grows, always convert counts to rates before drawing conclusions.

END QUESTION